

M O N D A Y

WHICH WAY IS UP? *Level*

SCRIPTURE TEXT:

**“You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart,
with all your soul, and with all your strength.”**

Deuteronomy 6: 5 (NKJV)



LESSON OBJECTIVE

Imagine this: You are going on a long hike to see a fantastic view from a certain mountain peak—it might be Table Mountain in South Africa, the Matterhorn in Switzerland or Italy, Mount Denali in the USA, or Mount Fuji in Japan. Maybe you want to think about some smaller mountain where you live! However, during your hike, the climb gets steeper and more challenging. Soon, you begin to wonder if there is a quicker and easier path. You see several colored arrows pointing in different directions. However, there's only one arrow for the mountain peak you desire to see, and the path you're on is the only way to get there. You're on the right track. If you keep going a little longer, you will get there.

Many false gods in our world today try to point us away from the one true God. When we follow the path God provided for us and follow His plan, we will experience His extraordinary love, grace, and forgiveness.

“Jesus said to him, ‘I am the way, the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me.’” John 14:6



The Battle of the Gods.

Read 1 Kings 18:20-29

Have you noticed that most Christians don't name their children "Ahab" or "Jezebel" for a good reason? King Ahab was considered one of the worst kings of Israel. When he disobeyed God and married pagan princess Jezebel, he started serving and worshipping Baal (1 Kings 16:31). Once again, the children of Israel accepted poor directions and influences and forgot to worship only Yahweh or Jehovah, the one true God. The God that Moses told them to love "with all your heart and soul and strength" before he died. They started worshipping the Baal gods (Baal was a prominent storm god and fertility god) and other gods and goddesses. Many abandoned worshipping the Creator God, while others tried to worship the gods of Baal in addition to Yahweh.

Elijah (whose name means "Yahweh is my God") was commanded by God to go to meet Ahab. Elijah always followed God's directions, so when God spoke, he obeyed. As Elijah climbed Mount Carmel, he could see King Ahab arriving in his royal robes, his prophets, and the Israelites who, as mentioned before, were straddling the fence between their dedication to Yahweh and the pagan gods of their king, Ahab, and his devious pagan wife, Jezebel. Since Mount Carmel was Baal's turf, Elijah, as directed by God, gave the prophets of Baal the "home-field advantage."

Today, like the Israelites, many of us Christian are riding the fence. In many ways serving other gods while intending to worship the one true God. Most of us genuinely believe we are only worshipping the true God and may not recognize how other gods have captured our attention and affection sneakily and innocently. In yesterday's devotional, we discussed making a mission statement that includes what you want your family to look like and what characteristics would represent your family. What you **do not** want your family to look like or have is equally important.

Today, take time to reflect on what false gods might be vying for your worship. While some may even be good, these might be things or activities that send us in the wrong direction, away from God rather than closer to Him. Some of these may include smart devices, social media, academics, sports, busyness, and other activities that become false altars if we don't put them in their proper place, space, and time. Make a commitment to look only to Jesus to point you in the right direction and fulfill all your deepest desires, wants, and needs.



PRAYER

Dear God, You are the one true God and we are Your servants. We want to obey Your Word. Please help us to believe in You and not allow other gods to take Your place. We love You with all our hearts and strength. In Jesus' name, amen.

APPLY IT & LIVE IT



BIBLE CHALLENGE

Practice the memory verse together as a family. Try saying it in the present tense: ***“I will love the Lord my God with all my heart, all my soul, and with all my strength.”***



REBUILDING THE FAMILY ALTAR



MAKE A PLAN

Decide as a family what you will do during family worship: sing or play the same song, read a bible text, bible passage, devotional, or sabbath school lesson.



CREATE A WORSHIP CALENDAR

Set a time for morning and evening worship that best fits the schedules of your family members. This will require rescheduling worship time according to family activities' seasonal, school, and work variations. Have worship during breakfast, during the drive to school, at dinner time, or right before bed at night. When you set a schedule for family worship, you are more likely to have it. It allows you to control activities to allow time for worship.



FAMILY TALK

Answer individually and as a family:

- Do you ever find yourself worshipping at the wrong altar?
- Can you identify specific activities, attitudes, or belongings that have already become or could become false gods in your life or home?
- How might you be ‘calling’ on these things listed above to meet inner needs and yearnings?
- What can you do to change your worship altar to focus first on the God of heaven and earth?

HAVE A WORSHIP EMERGENCY PLAN

There will be times when you can't follow the schedule. Choose one thing that you do every time you have worship. When the schedule gets off balance, do at least that one thing. It might be a special song that you sing or reciting a favorite bible text.

While it may not be in everyone's toolbox, most carpenters have a level tool. It is used to determine if a surface is horizontal or vertical. Without a level, you can't build a house that works well or looks good—you wouldn't even be able to put up a door properly. The level helps to keep everything in balance. We all want to feel level in our lives; some call it balance or equilibrium.

Having regular family worship times can help keep your family life in balance. It may seem like it may put you out of balance. However, when we worship God and bring him purposefully into our homes, we receive the centering or leveling from having the Spirit of God flow through us. Just keep doing it until you can't do without it.